THE MILL RIVER TRAIL

A green corridor from East Rock Park to New Haven Harbor, built by neighbors and backed by the city, state and federal government.

How it started

Alder **Tom Holahan** believed New Haven was the only city worth living in, and that its river should belong to the people who live beside it. In the 2000s he and his friends cleared a path along the Mill River between Humphrey Street and Grand Avenue and set out benches by the water. It was the last project he worked on before he passed away in 2007.

In 2014 volunteers hacking through the knotweed found his benches under the brush. The trail effort restarted that day, and it has not stopped since.

Where it stands

Two phases of paved trail are open along the east bank in Fair Haven. A green stormwater park at Haven and Exchange turned four blocks of dead roadway into a living classroom. The District built its own stretch of riverbank.

The Mill River Trail is now one of the **five greenways New Haven has committed to complete by 2030**, and the next section, from the District under I-91 to Blake Field and the Ralph Walker Rink, is under city contract.

$3.6M
Federal Transportation Alternatives award to the city for the trail, February 2025

2030
The city's target for finishing the Mill River Greenway under its Greenways 2030 plan

Tuesdays
Volunteer workdays at 5 pm, spring through fall. Gloves and tools provided

Four centuries of river. Twelve years of trail.

1642
First mill on the river, near East Rock

1798
Eli Whitney builds his armory on the Mill River

1860
Dammed. Lake Whitney becomes the city's first water supply

1970
Citizens defeat a highway planned over the river

2004
Tom Holahan walks the route with the National Park Service

2014
Volunteers find Tom's benches and restart the trail

2016
State awards $289,151 to design and build two segments

2019
Phase One opens along the east bank in Fair Haven

2020
Phase Two opens behind Grand Paint

2022
Haven and Exchange green infrastructure park opens

2025
$3.6M federal award. Greenways 2030. The Tom Holahan Fund

2026
City contracts the District-to-Blake Field section under I-91

Mill River Trail Advocates, a volunteer group. The Mill River Watershed Association is our fiduciary.

millriver.trailteam.org

What we are working on now

Under I-91 to Blake Field

The missing link from the District's riverbank to the Ralph Walker Rink. Designed in 2017 with state funds, bid by the city this spring, expected to break ground this fall.

Underpass Park

A park beneath the highway at State and James, designed with 30+ high school students and architect Alexis Sablone. First designs unveiled April 2026. underpasspark.org

Historic signs on the trail

Ten bilingual panels, each standing where its story happened: the stolen submarine, the dam, the bath house, Ball Island, the box factory and more. Five are at proof stage. Read them at signs.millrivertrail.com

Willow Street tunnel and Wilbur Cross

The $3.6 million federal award pays for trail along the rail line and a pedestrian tunnel under Willow Street, a safe walk to Wilbur Cross.

North into Hamden with the RWA

The Regional Water Authority is reviewing an official trail on its land from Dixwell Avenue to South New Road. Hamden holds its own federal grant for Armory to Putnam.

Tuesdays: plant, water, clear

Red oaks, bayberries and day lilies planted with the Urban Resources Initiative. Knotweed cut back at the District. Trash out, sight lines open.

Where it is going

In October 2025 the city launched **Greenways 2030**: five connected greenways to finish by the end of the decade, the Mill River Trail among them, with $37 million in local, state and federal funds behind the network. The city is planning a **Mill River Park** at the old English Station, and the long game is a river route from **Sleeping Giant to the Sound**.

The Tom Holahan Fund for the Mill River Trail

A permanent endowment at The Community Foundation for Greater New Haven, started by Susan Holahan with a $10,000 gift. Its income pays for what grants rarely cover: tools, plantings, interns, signs and art.

We met the goal. Your generosity and gifts at the event carried the fund past $20,000, so its income now supports projects and volunteer work along the trail in perpetuity. Gifts of $500 or more join the **Founders' Circle**.

Give at millrivertrail.com/donate or by check to The Community Foundation for Greater New Haven, memo "Tom Holahan Fund for the Mill River Trail."

Keep up with us

Workdays Tuesdays, 5 pm

Events and sign-up
millriver.trailteam.org

History and news millrivertrail.com

Email info@millrivertrail.com

Scan to get the weekly trail digest and RSVP for workdays and walks.

Partners: City of New Haven, Town of Hamden, Urban Resources Initiative, Save the Sound, Regional Water Authority, Mill River Watershed Association, and the property owners along the river.